

Case Western Reserve University
Weatherhead School of Management
MGMT 205—Essentials of Personal Finance – Spring 2025
Section 100: Tuesdays 2:30-3:45 p.m. PBL 05
Section 101: Thursdays 2:30-3:45p.m. PBL 05

Professor: Mary B Sasmaz, PhD, CPA, CFP
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Office Hours: Tuesdays 10:00am – 11:30am in my office, or by appointment.
Calendar Link for appointments:
<https://calendar.app.google/G5vyaJdBLFDMpJ1M8>
Course Website: canvas.case.edu
Mode of Instruction: In Person
Pre-requisites: None

Course description:

The goal of this course is to provide students of all disciplines with an essential foundation in personal finance. Through participating fully in this course, students will gain the knowledge and skills they need to make wise financial decisions as they move forward in life.

The course will focus on four core areas of personal finance:

- 1) Saving for short term goals and retirement
- 2) Making your money grow through investing
- 3) Controlling debt
- 4) Using insurance to minimize financial risk

The course will also introduce students to the essentials of income taxation and estate planning.

By the end of this course, students will have created the following reference materials they can use to guide their future financial decisions:

- 1) A “*Personal finance journal*” containing key points they want to remember about each topic
- 2) A set of *Life Application Activities* that puts their knowledge into practice
- 3) A “personal budget” for their first year out of college/graduate school
- 4) A reflection on their biggest “take aways” from the course

Required materials

- StockTrack Subscription for Simulation. Register with your CaseID email (ex. mbs26@case.edu). A link to register and purchase the simulation is posted on Canvas. The cost of the simulation access is \$19.99 for the semester.
- “Your Money Ratios: 8 Simple Tools for Financial Security at Every Stage of Life” by Charles Farrell, J.D., LL.M. The bookstore may have some copies. Kindle version and

hardcopies are also available on Amazon for less than \$10 and \$20, respectively. You may also be able to access a digital copy of the book on a library or other internet archive site.

- Links to other assigned readings and videos will be posted on Canvas.

OPTIONAL Recommended Reading Material:

“Quit like a Millionaire”, by Kristy Shen and Bryce Leung
“The Simple Path to Wealth: Your roadmap to financial independence” by J.L. Collins
“The Mondy Book for the Young, Fabulous, & Broke” by Suze Orman
“Financial Planning for Dummies” by Eric Tyson
“The Everything Personal Finance in your 20s and 30s Book” by Howard Davidoff

Course workload per university standards

In addition to the in-class contact time, “For undergraduate courses, each one credit hour also includes associated work that can be completed by a typical student in **2-3 hours of effort outside the classroom.**”

Course structure

The structure of this course will be as follows:

1) Class Preparation: Before-class reading and/or videos

Each week you’ll have approximately 30-60 minutes of readings/videos to set the groundwork for each class. **The links to articles and videos will be posted in the weekly Canvas Module.** I typically post materials a couple of weeks in advance, so students have flexibility related to timing for any prep work.

2) Class: Weekly classes will be held in person in the classroom designated by WSOM, currently listed as PBL 05. Class time will include lecture and other in-class activities.

3) Following each class:

1. Concept Quiz and Personal Finance Journal Entry: You will have the opportunity to demonstrate understanding of the main takeaways and reflect on their impact to your personal life with a Concept Quiz and Personal Finance Journal Entry. I encourage you to create a word document titled “My Personal Finance Journal” and add to it each week. You will also submit this file at the end of the semester as a compilation of your journal entries so creating a document and adding to it each week will make this easier. You will copy and paste your journal entries into the weekly “quiz.” The journal is meant to help you internalize the readings/videos and to act as a “take away” that you can look back on in the future to help guide your financial actions and decisions. **The journal entries should NOT be a simple listing of facts or notes, but rather your own *personal reaction to (or synthesis of) the article/video/assigned reading that you want to take with you from the course.*** What did you learn that you really want to put into practice now or in the future? What did you really find interesting? What would you really want your friends and siblings to know? How do your own life circumstances interplay with

what you have read, viewed, or learned? Perhaps you see things differently than an article author or the course instructor. A personal finance journal template has been provided for you at the end of this document (before the calendar). Again, you will copy and paste your journal entry into the weekly assignment in canvas. The concept quiz and journal entry will be due each week by **Monday at midnight** though I encourage you to do these either before class based on the readings and/or prep material or as soon as possible after class while the material is fresh.

2. Life Application Activities: You'll also have the opportunity to apply the concepts to your own life by completing "*life application activities*". You'll need to submit **10 activities** (out of more than 20 available). While there are some specific life applications that are required, you will choose the remaining to reach the 10 required activities for the semester. Deadlines are based on when the topics are covered, so you should plan ahead if specific topics are of interest. You may complete all the life application assignments but only 10 will count toward your grade. You should upload them to Canvas by the **next week on Tuesday at midnight**. This deadline allows you to come to office hours on Tuesday should you have questions before submitting. The activities vary in length, but in general should take about 15-45 minutes to complete. You'll see the weekly due dates for assignments on Canvas but keep in mind that you only are required to complete 10 of them throughout the semester; not all of them, so while canvas will automatically post a 0 for incomplete activities, the lowest ones will be dropped from your grade at the end of the semester to result in a total of 10 counting toward your grade. I encourage you to track your course grade separately from canvas as the grade will be distorted in canvas until the drop of non-included scores at the end of the semester. See canvas for a "What's my Grade" tool that you can download and track your scores.

4) Budgeting Simulation: Throughout the semester, you will participate in an online budgeting simulation game. You will learn how to manage cash flow, savings goals, and credit over the course of this class. The simulation is an 18-month game. Each week you may play up to 2 months of the game. By the game completion date, you will have played the game for 18 months. You must complete the full game. The attached course schedule provides a recommendation of months to play in order to complete the "18 months" of the game by the due date. You may choose to play 2 months in a week that 1 month is suggested, just keep in mind that the maximum you can play per week is 2 months of the simulation and you must play all 18 months of the game by the posted due date. You should maintain a log of notes to yourself to remember when playing (such as due dates of bills, reminders to save and when, etc.) as well as any takeaways from the mini-lessons within the game.

At the start of the game, you will be a college student with a part-time job. Your income will vary due to variable hours of work as a student. After 6 months of play, you will "graduate" and get a full-time job. Throughout the game you will have to make spending and saving decisions.

5.) Final Project - End of semester synthesis: As a means to "pull it all together" you will be required to complete a final open-note **reflection** and a hypothetical **personal budget** for your first year after graduation. Your weekly journal entries should prove helpful for the reflection portion of this assignment.

*****Please note that Canvas will deduct 20% from your score for **each day** any assignment is late.*****

REMINDER: Only 10 Life Application Activities are required. While you'll get a zero on Canvas for those you don't complete, all scores will be dropped except for the 10 you complete.

Course Grades*:

Grade Category	Notes	Grade %
Weekly Concept Quizzes and Personal Finance Journal Entries	(Lowest 1 dropped)	30%
Participation	Attendance and Participation Activities (1 dropped)	10%
Choice Assignments:	Life application activities (10 required, remainder dropped)	30%
Budget Game	Complete by Session 13	10%
Final Reflection & Personal Budget	Details will be posted to Canvas	20%
Total		100%

***Grades on late assignments are automatically reduced by 20% for every day they are late. Canvas automatically posts a zero if the assignment is not turned in by the due date but will be graded and any penalty will automatically be applied by canvas.**

Academic Integrity

All students in this course are expected to adhere to university standards of academic integrity. Cheating, plagiarism, and other forms of academic dishonesty will not be tolerated. This includes, but is not limited to turning in written work that was prepared by someone other than you or making minor modifications to the work of someone else and turning it in as your own. Ignorance will not be permitted as an excuse. If you are not sure whether something you plan to submit would be considered either cheating or plagiarism, it is your responsibility to ask for clarification. When your name appears on a group product for a class, you are responsible for the integrity of the work, even if you did not personally write the offending material.

Artificial Intelligence

Much of this course requires you to reflect and/or internalize the implications of your learning on your own life, thus the submission of reflections created with artificial intelligence programs (e.g. ChatGPT) **is not appropriate and will be considered academic dishonesty.** The use of Artificial Intelligence to summarize general information may be appropriate for gaining basic knowledge on a particular topic, however it is not appropriate to blindly rely on results of AI without checking sources, especially for technical rules in financial planning available on the internet that may have become outdated. AI cannot “reflect” on the implication of the material on YOUR life.

Information on citations and plagiarism can be found on the following web sites:

- <https://canvas.case.edu/courses/22890/pages/research-tools-databases-and-more>
- <https://wts.indiana.edu/writing-guides/plagiarism.html>

The academic integrity policies and procedures that govern all undergraduates can be found at:

- <https://bulletin.case.edu/undergraduate-studies/academic-integrity/>
- <https://case.edu/studentlife/conduct/academic-integrity-resources>

Disability Resources

Students at CWRU are not required to disclose disability information to anyone. However, in order to use services and appropriate accommodations, students should notify Disability Resources in 402 Sears Building. The Disability Resources staff members that are aware of your disability will keep this information confidential. Disability Resources will work closely with students and design an individual plan for accommodations. Accommodations and services are available for students with a variety of disabilities including: visual impairment, hearing impairment, mobility limitations, chronic illness, psychological disorders and learning disabilities. We are able to offer the following: testing accommodations, adaptive equipment and assistive technology, scheduling assistance, transportation assistance, alternate format for print materials, note taking assistance, interpreters, parking assistance and accessible housing. This list is not exhaustive and other accommodations may be appropriate.

Beginning fall 2023, this course satisfies the GER Wellness requirement.

Justification:

Research shows that anxiety related to money and finances, financial anxiety, affects nearly all Americans. This anxiety leads to financial stress, which directly contributes to health issues and a lower quality of life. To combat this issue, educational institutions, including institutions of higher education, are being called upon to incorporate financial education into their curricula. By doing so, students will have the skills and knowledge necessary to support their own wellbeing and reduce the stress caused by financial anxiety. This course helps prepare students on their financial journey by creating several reference materials they can use to guide their future financial decisions, including a: “Personal Finance Journal” containing key points they want to remember about each topic; “Personal Budget” for their first year out of college/graduate school; and set of Life Application Activities that puts their knowledge into practice.

Source: “How Does Financial Stress Affect Your Health?”, By Christine Byrne and Kelley Holland, Medically Reviewed by Allison Young, MD on May 12, 2022

A nationwide survey of more than 3,000 adults published by Thrive Global and the credit card Discover in March 2022, found that 90 percent reported that money was a source of stress.

Data collected in 2019 by Everyday Health for the United States of Stress survey for more than 6,700 men and women found that money was our number one source of stress with 52 percent of people saying financial issues regularly stressed them out.\

“To say that financial stress impacts health is an understatement,” says Ashley Agnew...That’s because our finances affect so many aspects of our lives, including our safety, opportunities available to us, and relationships, she says. “Our relationship with money and our thoughts surrounding finances are big drivers of our health.”

Over time, having lots of financial stress — particularly when combined with the lack of sleep that such stress can cause... can lead to complex trauma, Dr. Melkumian says.

Source: “Where the Weaknesses Are in Student Financial Wellness”, Melissa Ezarik, February 25, 2022

About four in 10 students surveyed rate their financial knowledge as either excellent (7 percent) or good (35 percent), while only 12 percent rate it as poor.

Source: U.S. Financial Literacy and Education Commission’s 2019 publication, “Best Practices for Financial Literacy and Education at Institutions of Higher Education”

Along with preparing the workforce, institutions of higher education can prepare their students to make financial choices throughout their lives that enable them to effectively participate in our economy, build wealth, and attain their goals.

A lack of financial education and financial literacy is common among the student population. Institutions of higher education can address this challenge by effectively engaging students in financial literacy and education. The FLEC recommends that institutions of higher education require mandatory financial literacy courses...integrate financial literacy into core curricula.

Example Personal Finance Journal Entry

The following is an example Personal Finance Journal Entry. Your responses should be copied and pasted into the Weekly Concept Quiz and Personal Finance Journal Assignment.

My Personal Finance Journal

Week #2

Topic: Saving and Spending Habits

Important Topic Notes (optional):

Future To Dos (optional):

In the space below, reflect on this week's materials.

(The journal entry should NOT be a simple listing of facts or notes, but rather your own *personal reaction* to (*or synthesis* of) the article/video/assigned reading that you want to take with you from the course. What did you learn that you really want to put into practice now or in the future? What did you really find interesting? What would you really want your friends and siblings to know? How do your own life circumstances interplay with what you have read, viewed, or learned? Perhaps you see things differently than an article author or the course instructor.)

Personal Finance Journal Entry:

Tentative Course Schedule

Class	Date		Topic & Prep Materials (Read/Watch BEFORE class) each week.	Weekly Concept Quiz and Personal Finance Journal Entry Do each Monday at Midnight	Life Application Activities*** Due by Tuesday at midnight. (Choose 10, except where required)	Budgeting Game Simulation** Do Weekly
1	1/14 or 1/16	Tu Th	Course overview and introduction Psychology and Money: Attitudes towards money, wealth, and spending.	CQ&PF Journal 1 (questionnaire)		Video: Game Tutorial Play at least 1 Month of Budget Game
2	1/21 or 1/23	Tu Th	1/24 End of Drop Add Saving and Spending habits. Budgeting best practices.	CQ&PF Journal 2	2.1 Automate savings 2.2 Tracking spending and bills	Play 2 months of Budget Game
3	1/28 or 1/30	Tu Th	Credit Scores and Credit Cards	CQ&PF Journal 3	3.1 Credit Report 3.2 Credit score 3.3 Credit Cards 3.3 Identity theft	Play 1 month of Budget Game
4	2/4 or 2/6	Tu Th	Social Security, Saving for retirement, and Time Value of Money	CQ&PF Journal 4	4.1 Time value of money* (REQ) 4.2 Social Security Account	Play 2 month of Budget Game
5	2/11 or 2/13	Tu Th	Types of retirement Accounts	CQ&PF Journal 5	5.1 How much to save for retirement	Play 1 month of Budget Game
6	2/18 or 2/20	Tu Th	Investing Part 1	CQ&PF Journal 6	6.1 Portfolio allocation (REQ) 6.2 Portfolio Game	Play 2 month of Budget Game

7	2/25 or 2/26	T u T h	Investing Part 2	CQ&PF Journal 7	7.1 Investing in index funds 7.2 Investing in real estate	Play 1 month of Budget Game
8	3/4 Or 3/6	T u T h	Intro to Debt: Housing and Student Loans	CQ&PF Journal 8	8.1 Student loans* (REQ – Required if you have student loans) 8.2 How much House can you afford?	Play 2 month of Budget Game
	3/11 Or 3/13	T u T h	SPRING BREAK – NO CLASS			
9	3/18 or 3/20	T u T h	Debt: Vehicle Loans and Leases	CQ&PF Journal 9	9.1 Vehicle comparison 9.2 Interview Financially Successful* (REQ)	Play 2 months of Budget Game
10	3/25 Or 3/27	T u T h	Insurance Part 1: Property & Casualty	CQ&PF Journal 10	10.1 Car Insurance Cost 10.2 Car Insurance Scenarios	Play 2 months of Budget Game
11	4/1 or 4/3	T u T h	Insurance Part 2: Disability, Life and Health	CQ&PF Journal 11	11.1 Life insurance cost 11.2 Health Insurance costs	Play 2 months of Budget Game
12	4/8 Or 4/10	T u T h	Taxation – Payroll and Income	CQ&PF Journal 12	12.1 Personal Budget Tax Effects (REQ)	Play any remaining months of Budget Game Budget Game must be completed by Monday 4/14.

13	4/15 or 4/17	T u T h	Estate Planning and Family Wealth Transfers	CQ&PF Journal 13	13.1 POD/TOD Beneficiaries	Budget Game must be completed by Monday 4/14.
14	4/22 OR 4/24	T u T h	Final Wrap-up Topic TBD – Based on Class Feedback Possible Guest Speaker	Final Reflection & Personal Budget		

Notes:

This course schedule is not final. I reserve the right to make adjustments and changes as needed.

*Required

**The budget game is an 18-month budgeting simulation. The number of months to play the game is a suggested timeline to complete the entire simulation. The system will limit you to a max of 2 months play per week. You must complete the entire 18-month simulation by Week 13.

*** More options of activities may become available throughout the semester. Updates will be posted on canvas.